OPPOSITION ANALYSIS CASE STUDY

Spain at Euro 2024

The champions across seven matches, from StatsBomb open event data.



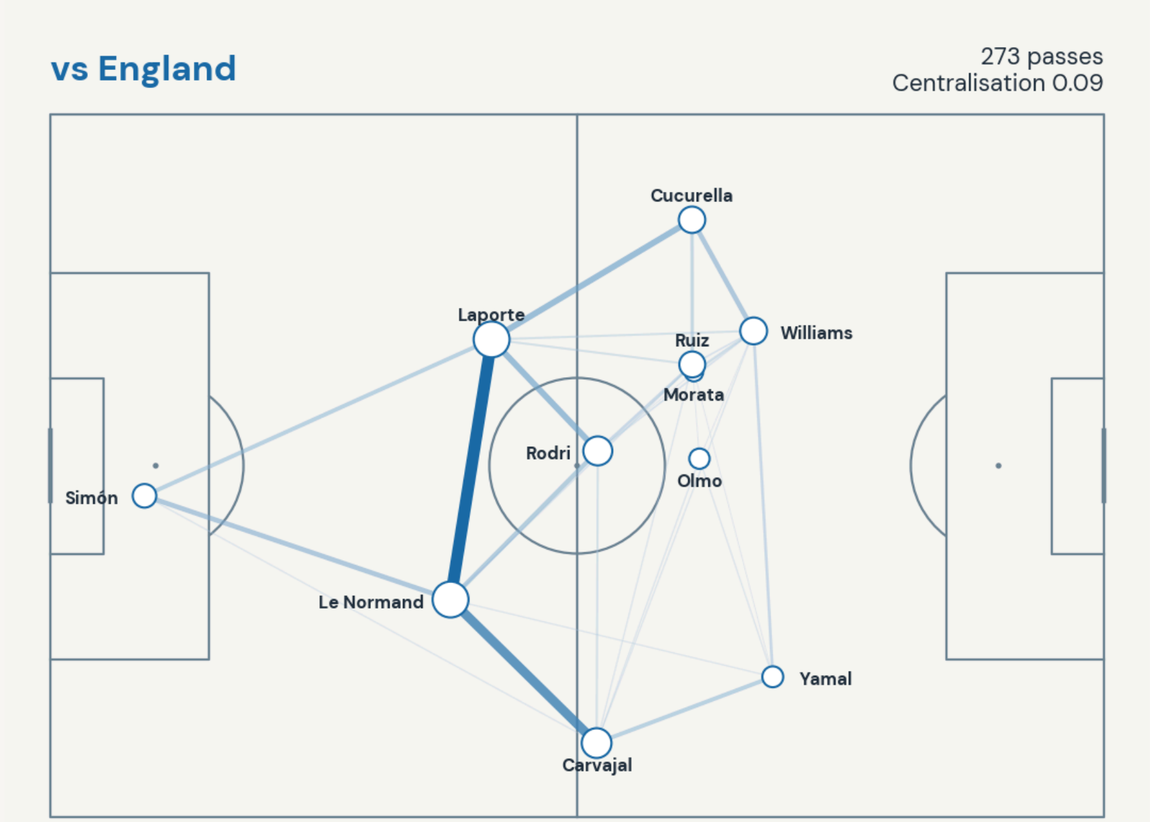
01

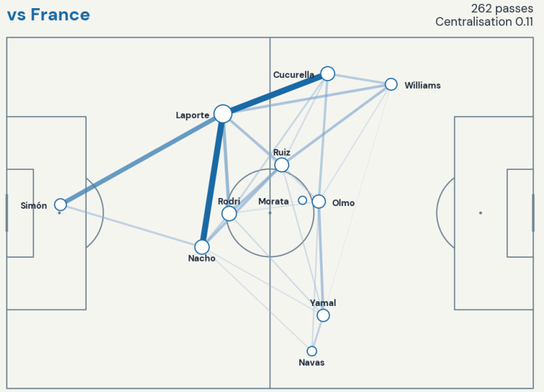
Offensive

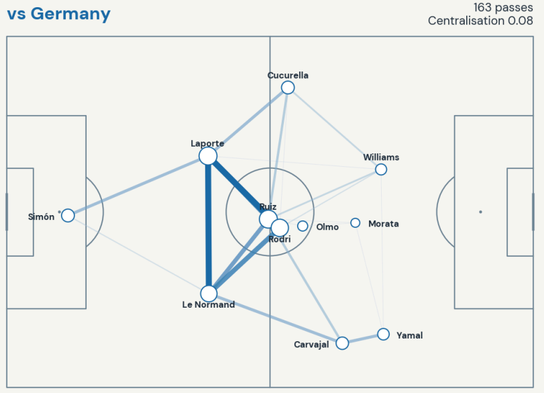
Spain with the ball. The passing shape in the knockouts, the half-spaces, the crosses and corners, and the shots.

OFFENSIVE

Wingers inside, full-backs high, the midfield deep







A circle is a player at his average position, sized by the passes he played. A thicker, darker line is more passes between that pair.

The final, with France and Germany for comparison.

Williams and Yamal play in the half-spaces.

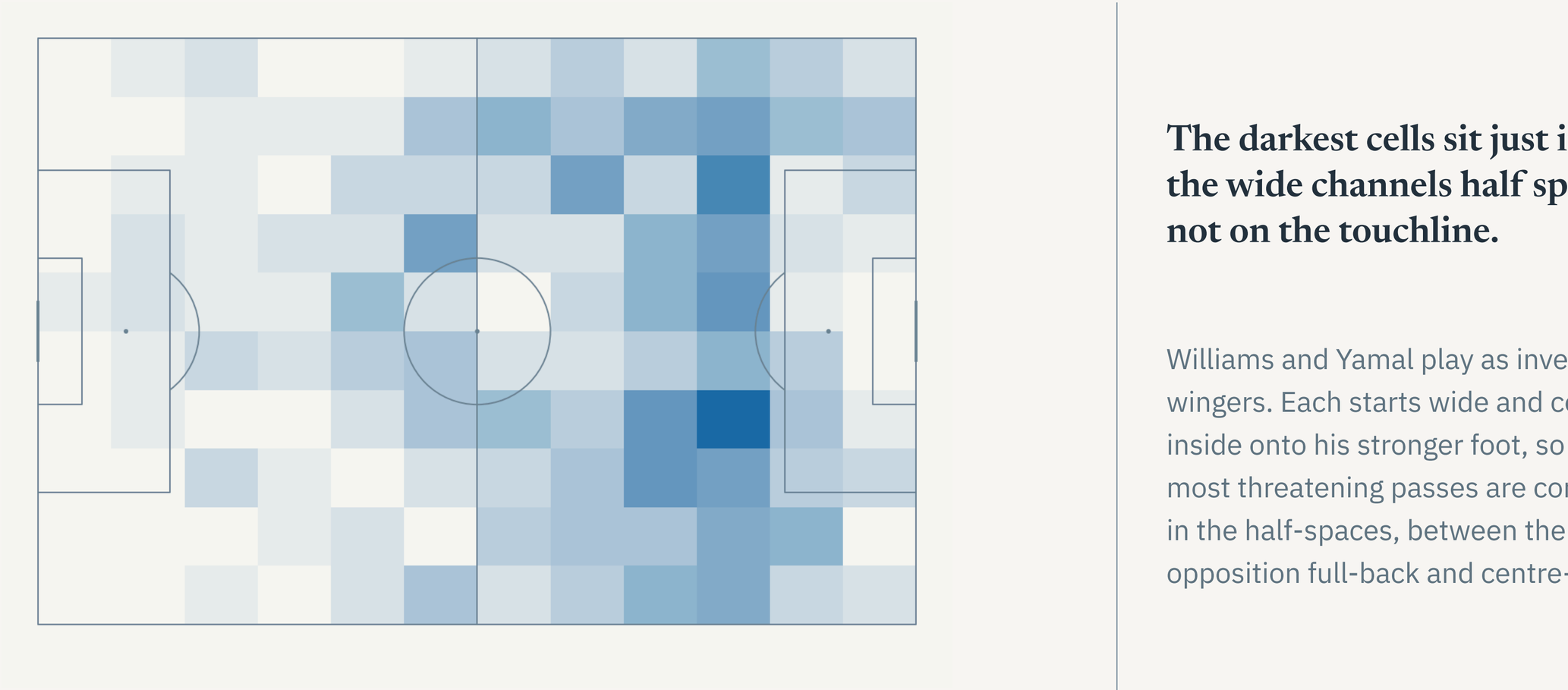
That pushes Cucurella and Carvajal forward on the flanks.

Rodri and Ruiz stay low to receive and play forward.

Morata drops back to make an overload, but rarely uses the ball.

OFFENSIVE

Dangerous passes came through the half-spaces



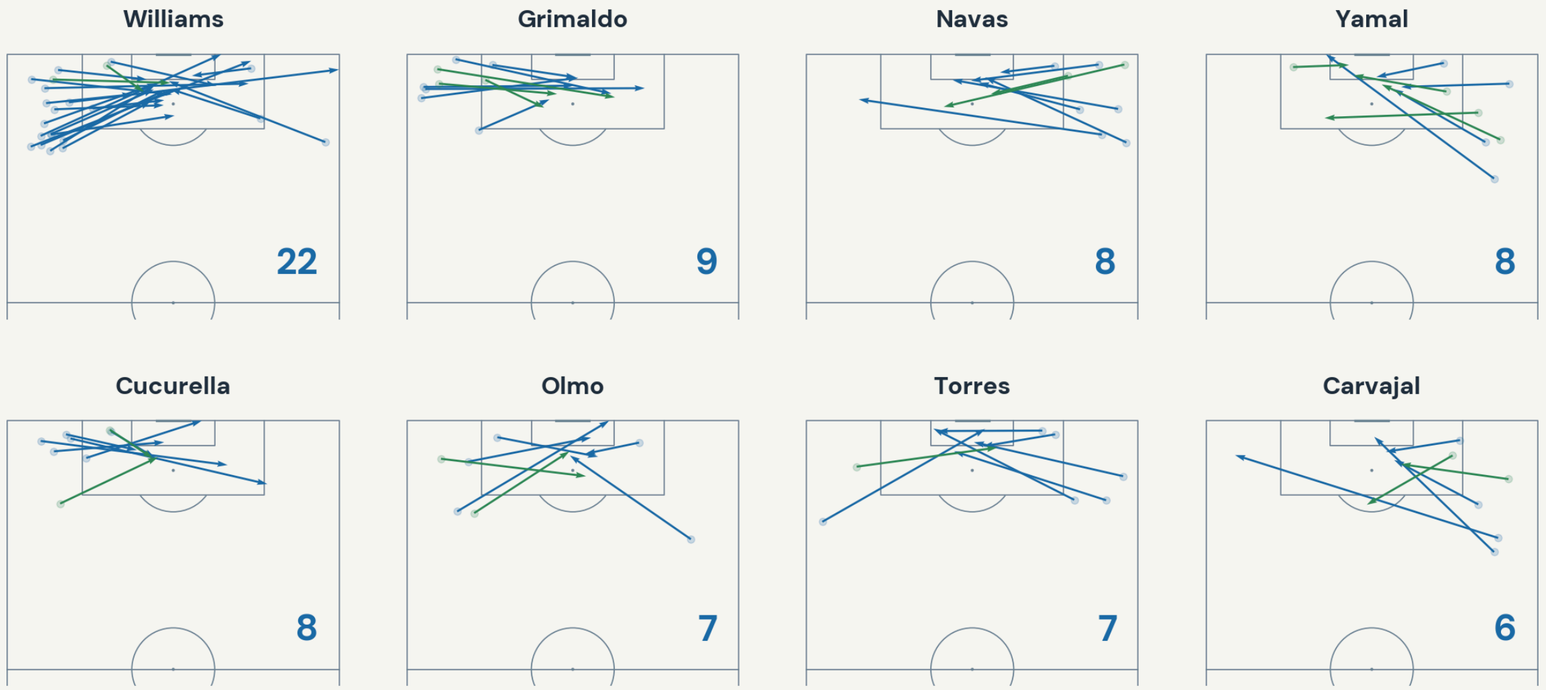
Each cell counts open-play passes in the 15 seconds before a Spain shot, placed where the pass started, and then divided by the number of games. Darker blue is more of those passes.

The darkest cells sit just inside the wide channels half spaces, not on the touchline.

Williams and Yamal play as inverted wingers. Each starts wide and comes inside onto his stronger foot, so Spain's most threatening passes are condensed in the half-spaces, between the opposition full-back and centre-back.

OFFENSIVE

Nico Williams was Spain's crosser



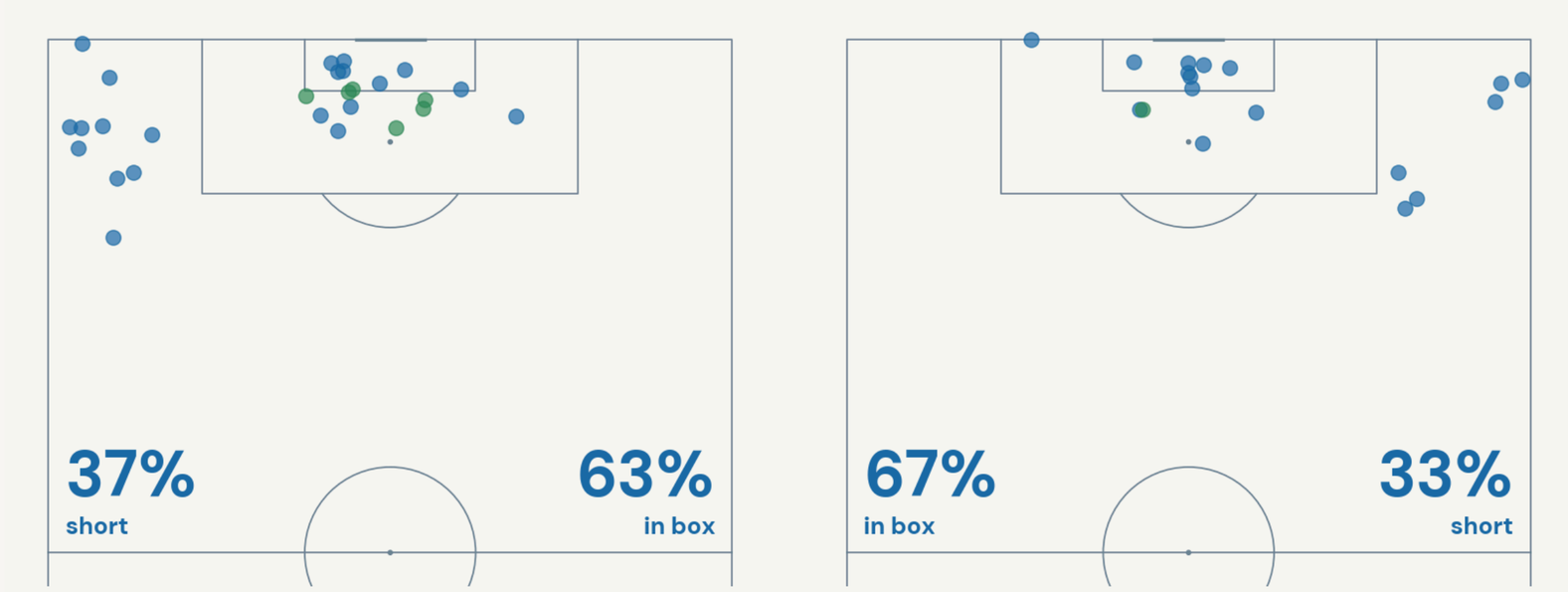
Each arrow is a cross, from where it was played to where it arrived. The number is that player's total. Green led to a shot or a goal.

22 crosses, more than twice the next player.

Grimaldo was next with 9. Williams crossed from the left, from wide of the box and across it, and several became shot assists (green). The rest of the squad split their crosses between both flanks, but the volume came down Williams' side.

OFFENSIVE

Most corners came from the left, and most went into the box



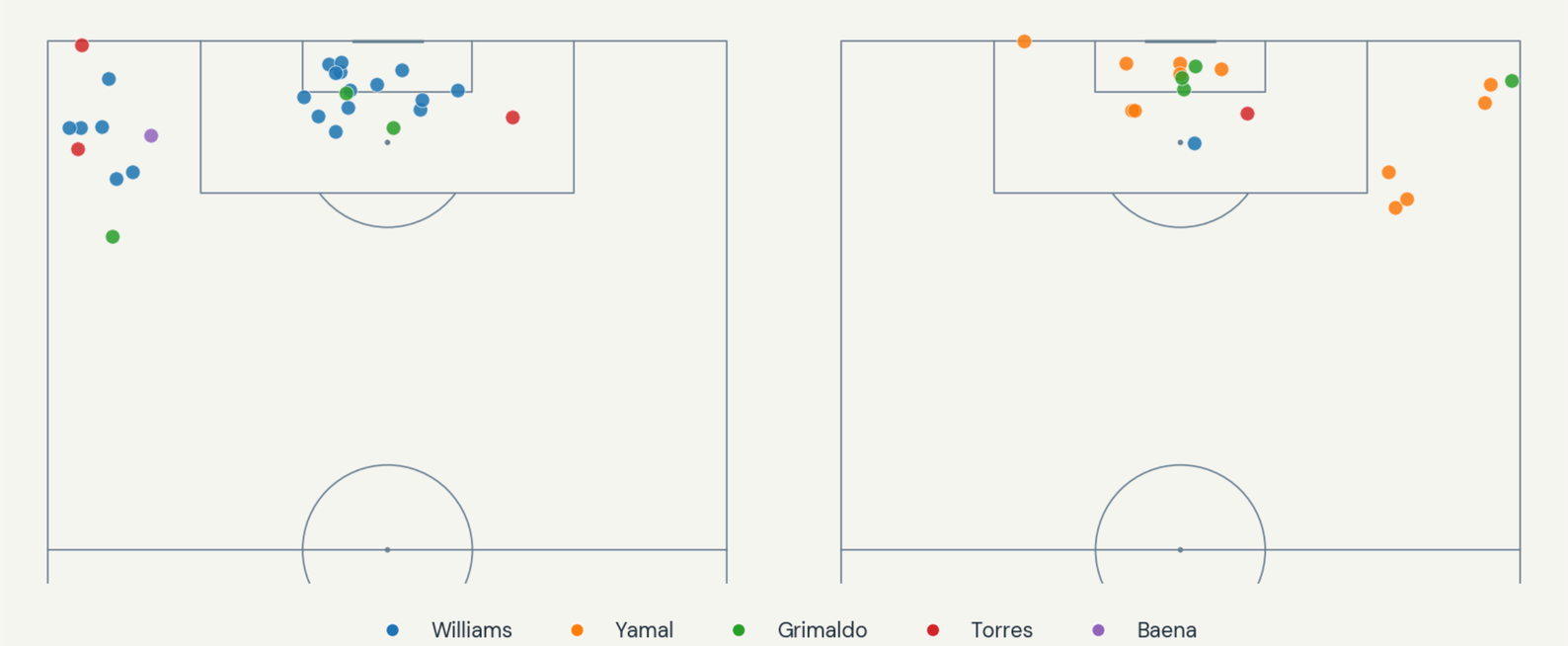
Each point is where the corner ended. Green led to a shot or a goal. Short means the corner did not end in the box.

27 corners from the left, 18 from the right.

About two in three went into the box from either side: 17 of 27 on the left, 12 of 18 on the right. The rest were played short. Six of the seven corners that led to a shot came from the left.

OFFENSIVE

Williams took the left, Yamal the right



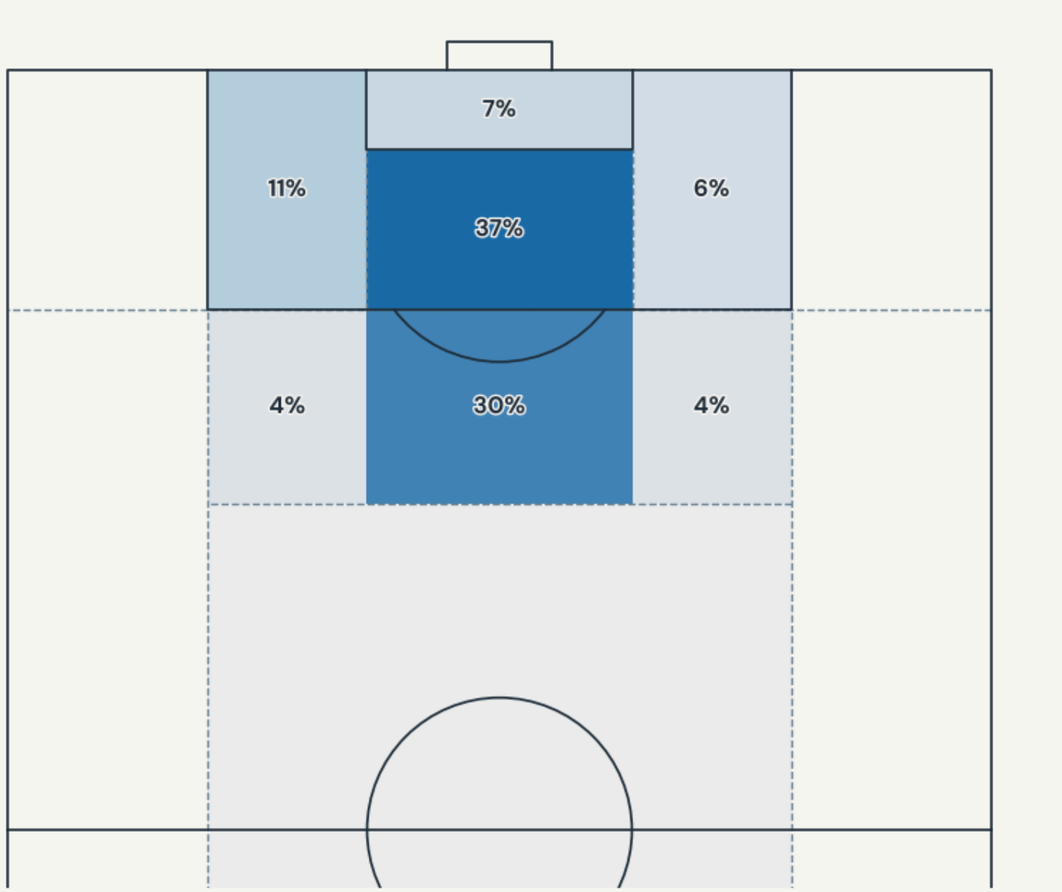
The same corner endings, split by the side they were taken from. Colour is the player who took the corner.

Williams took 20 of the 27 from the left. Yamal took 12 of the 18 from the right.

Four of Williams' corners led to a shot. Grimaldo was the alternative on both sides, with 7 corners and two shot assists. Torres and Baena took five more between them.

OFFENSIVE

Three in ten shots came from outside the box



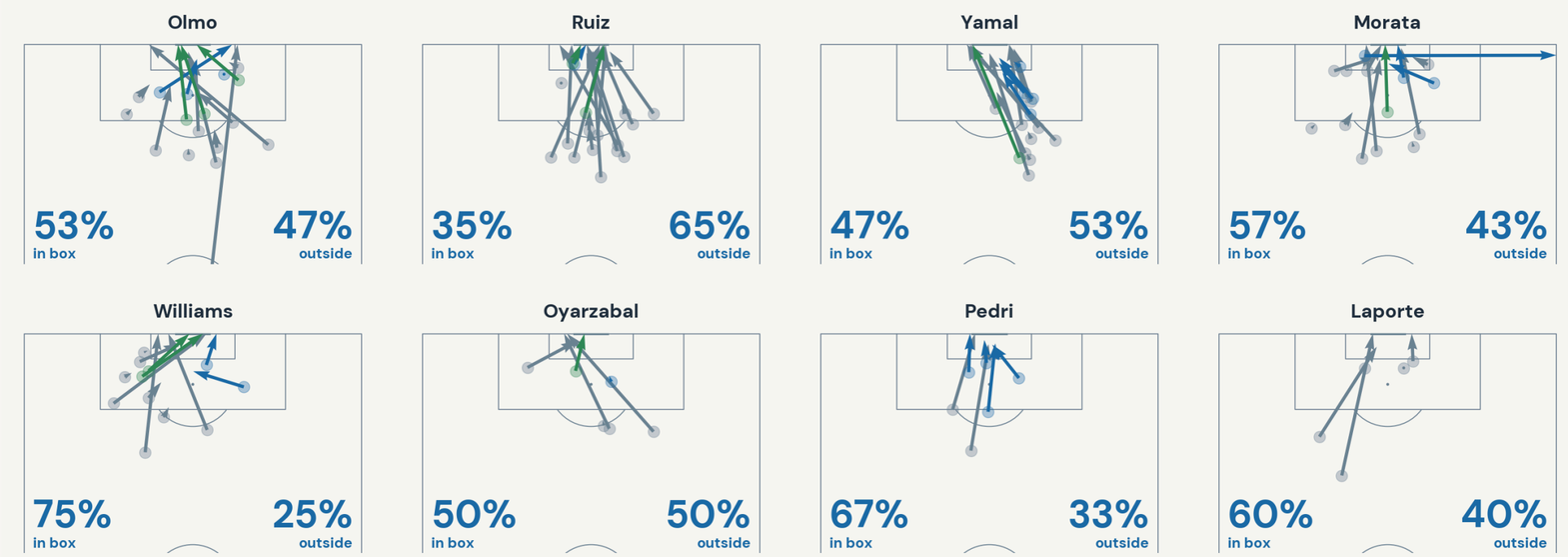
Each zone is coloured by Spain's share of their non-penalty shots. Darker blue is a higher share, and only zones above 5% are labelled.

37 of 123 non-penalty shots came from just outside the box, 30%.

Only the centre of the penalty area produced more, with 45 shots (37%). Spain did not wait for a clear sight of goal. When the block held, they shot from range.

OFFENSIVE

Four players were willing to shoot from distance



Each arrow runs from where the shot was taken to where it ended. Green is a goal. Blue is shot with xg > 0.1, The percentages are that player's shots inside the box and outside it.

Olmo, Yamal, Ruiz, and Morata likes shotting from outside the box.

Olmo and Ruiz arrived from midfield to shoot from the edge of the area. Yamal cut in from the right onto his left foot. Morata, usually the man inside the box, also tried from range.

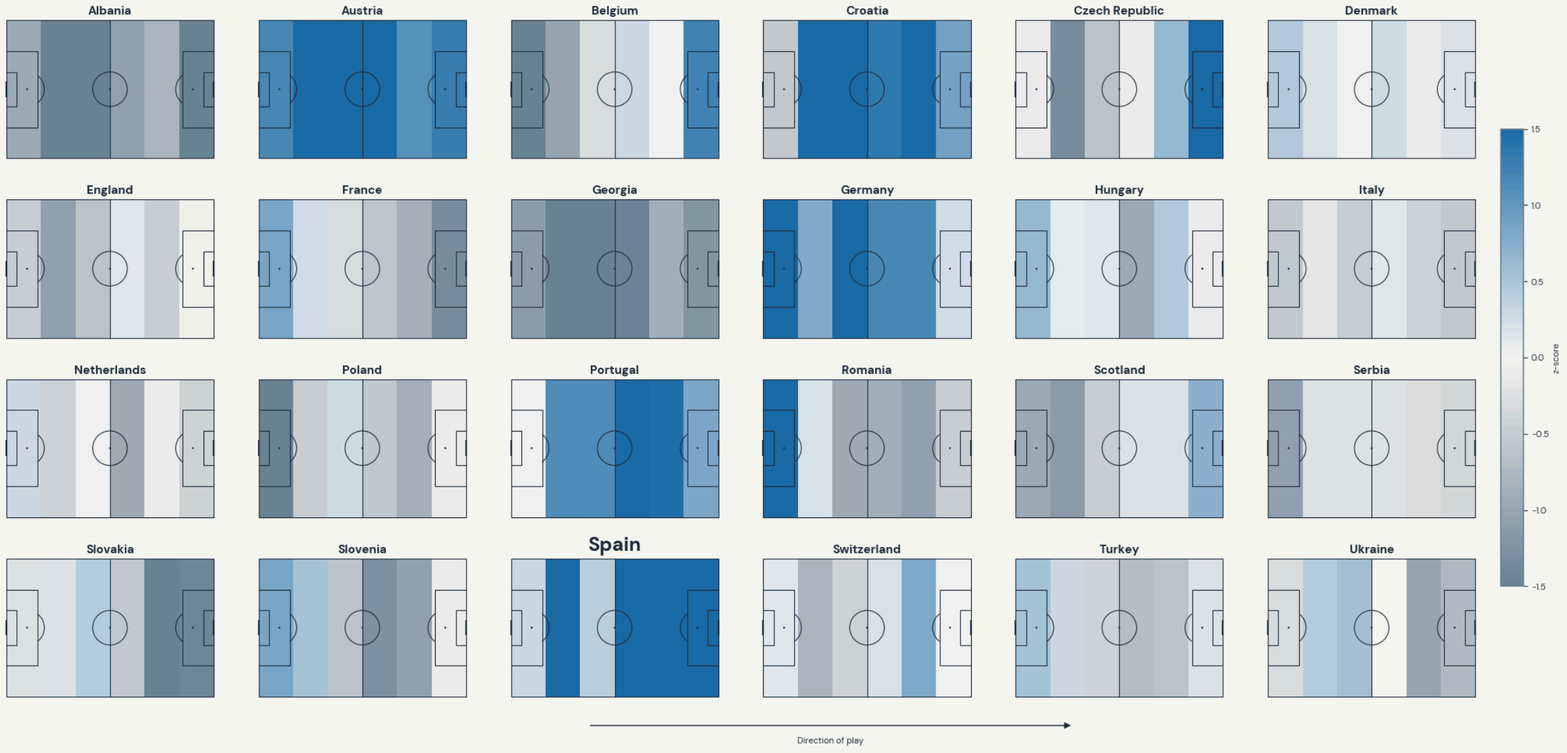
02

Defense

Spain without the ball, once the opponent had settled. Defensive actions for each pass they faced, in six bands of the pitch, against the rest of the tournament.

DEFENSE

Spain pressed harder than average across the whole pitch



Each pitch is one team, in six bands from their own goal to the opponent's. Blue is more defensive actions per opposition pass than the tournament average in that band. Grey is fewer, and a darker blue is further above. Direction of play is left to right.

Above the tournament average in all six bands.

Highest of all 24 teams in front of the opposition box, and second or third through the rest of the attacking half. Only Austria and Croatia came close to the same pattern.

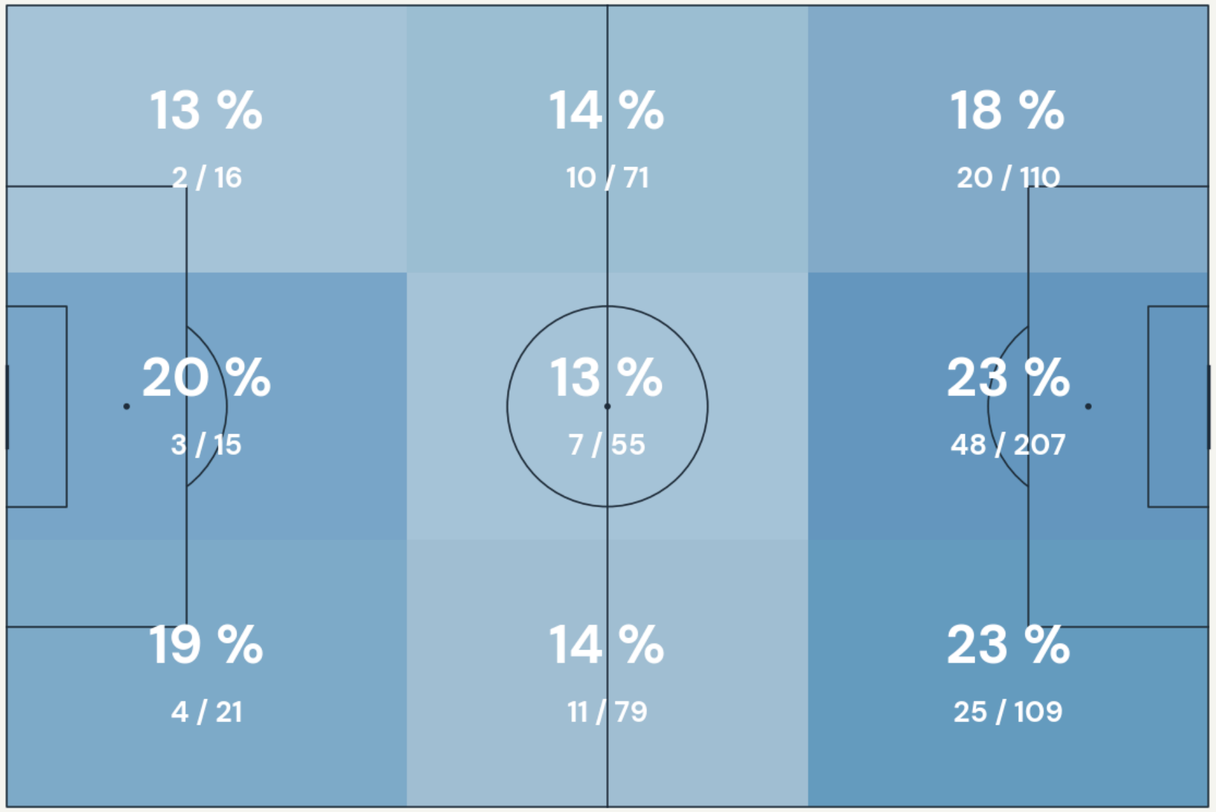
03

Defensive transition

The five seconds after a loss. Where Spain tried to win the ball straight back, before the opponent could play out.

DEFENSIVE TRANSITION

Spain won the ball straight back all over the pitch



The percentage is the share of losses Spain won back within five seconds, and the fraction is those regains over the losses.

19% dispossession won back within five seconds

The second highest rate at the tournament. The press did not switch off in any third: 13 to 20% in Spain's own and middle thirds, rising to 23% in the attacking third, where 48 of 207 central losses came straight back.